NATIONAL ASSEMBLY

Hon. Hamata's motivation for the Motion concerning the critical issue of extracting water from the Ohangwena Aquifer 2 as a vital resource for the Ohangwena Region and the broader northern regions of Namibia

September, 2024

Honorable Speaker, Honorable Members,

1. You can recall when I made my maiden speech in this August House. I spoke about how the people of the Ohangwena Region are suffering, and I stated unequivocally that it is unacceptable.
2. Honorable Speaker, today, after several months of sitting in this House, I wish to bring to your attention an important matter affecting over 245,000 residents of Ohangwena. Despite their plight, they are sitting on a valuable resource –an underground water reservoir known as the Ohangwena Aquifer 2.
3. This critical resource lies beneath our feet in the Ohangwena Region and holds the potential to transform not only agricultural prospects but also address the pressing issue of water scarcity for local communities.

4. The Ohangwena Aquifer 2 contains an estimated 5 billion cubic meters of water, with the capacity to sustainably provide about 20 million cubic meters annually. This substantial reserve offers a dual opportunity: to support agricultural development and to meet the vital drinking water needs of the Ohangwena Region's residents.

Honorable Speaker, Honorable Members,

5. Currently, the Ohangwena Region faces severe water shortages, impacting daily life and health. Access to clean drinking water is a fundamental human right, yet many communities in Ohangwena struggle to secure this essential resource. By extracting water from the Ohangwena Aquifer 2, we can ensure a reliable supply of clean drinking water for approximately 245,000 Namibians, significantly improving their quality of life and addressing a critical need.
6. In addition to providing drinking water, this aquifer presents a unique opportunity to revolutionize agriculture in the region. The fertile lands of Ohangwena are well-suited for cultivating a variety of crops, including maize, millet, sorghum, groundnuts, beans, and vegetables such as tomatoes, onions, and cabbage. With strategic investment in irrigation infrastructure, we can turn these potential resources into a thriving agricultural sector.
7. The agricultural development supported by this water resource has the potential to transform Ohangwena into a key agricultural hub for Namibia and the Southern African region. By harnessing the Ohangwena Aquifer 2, we can address local food security issues and create a sustainable source of food for our nation and our neighbors.

Honorable Speaker, Honorable Members,

8. The extraction of water from this aquifer can also address the high unemployment rate in Ohangwena, which stands at around 34%.[1] The agricultural sector has the potential to employ up to 30% of the workforce in the region, creating thousands of jobs and boosting the local economy. This investment will alleviate poverty and enhance living standards by providing stable, well-paying jobs.
9. Agriculture is a cornerstone of any sustainable economy. By leveraging the water from the Ohangwena Aquifer 2, we can significantly contribute to Namibia's gross domestic product (GDP) growth. Expanding the agricultural sector will improve economic stability and flexibility, lead to higher exports, and generate foreign exchange, contributing to overall economic development.
10. Furthermore, the development of agriculture through this project will stimulate broader economic growth, creating opportunities in related sectors such as transportation, logistics, and agro-processing. This will have a multiplier effect, driving additional investment and job creation across various industries.
11. Empowering our agricultural graduates is another crucial aspect of this initiative. Our universities and colleges produce approximately 1,500 skilled individuals annually in agriculture. Many of these graduates face employment challenges, and by developing the agricultural sector in Ohangwena, we can provide meaningful opportunities for these professionals.
12. The Agro-Marketing and Trade Agency (AMTA) will benefit from the increased agricultural output in Ohangwena. A greater variety and volume of products will enhance AMTA's role in promoting local produce,

[1] 2012 Namibia Labour Force Survey

reducing our reliance on imports, and stabilizing food prices, contributing to food security.

13. The economic benefits of this project are substantial. With increased agricultural production and improved access to drinking water, Ohangwena could contribute billions of Namibian dollars to our economy annually. This influx of revenue will support investments in healthcare, education, and infrastructure, redirecting funds currently spent on food imports to bolster our economy.

Honorable Speaker, Honorable Members,

14. Currently, Namibia spends an estimated N$3 billion annually on food imports. Successful agricultural development in Ohangwena has the potential to redirect these funds, reducing our dependency on imports and strengthening our economic resilience.

15. Our neighboring countries will also benefit from a thriving agricultural sector in Ohangwena. Increased agricultural output will enable us to export surplus produce to our neighbors, fostering regional trade, strengthening diplomatic ties, and contributing to the stability and prosperity of Southern Africa.

16. Namibia has the potential to become a key player in the regional agricultural market. By supplying high-quality, sustainably produced food to our neighbors, we can enhance our regional standing and promote economic collaboration.

Honorable Speaker, Honorable Members,

17. The extraction of water from the Ohangwena Aquifer 2 is a visionary project with the potential to transform our nation. It addresses critical needs for both drinking water and agricultural development, aligning with our national development goals and positioning Namibia as a leader in sustainable practices.

18. This initiative is not just about accessing water; it is about unlocking the potential of our people and land to build a brighter, more prosperous future. Let us seize this opportunity with the urgency and commitment it deserves.
19. By investing in the necessary infrastructure, supporting our farmers, and ensuring the efficient and sustainable implementation of this project, we can set Namibia on a path to economic growth and social development. The benefits will be far-reaching and long-lasting, creating a legacy of prosperity for future generations.
20. However, **Honorable Speaker**, **Honorable Members**, we must exercise caution in how we utilize this resource. The sustainability of the Ohangwena Aquifer 2 depends not only on the volume of water it holds but also on our ability to manage its extraction in line with its natural recharge rate. Over-extraction could deplete this resource prematurely, threatening the long-term water security of our region. Therefore, I urge that any development plan includes a comprehensive study on the aquifer's recharge rate and recommends an extraction rate that ensures the aquifer remains a reliable source of water for centuries to come.
21. Livestock farming will also benefit significantly from improved water access. Reliable water from the Ohangwena Aquifer 2 will support livestock health, expand herds, and enhance production. This will improve the livelihoods of rural farmers, providing income, food, and social status.
22. Improved livestock farming will complement agricultural production. Livestock manure can be used as natural fertilizer, enriching the soil and increasing crop yields by up to 20%. This integrated approach will create a sustainable, mutually beneficial cycle, maximizing the productivity of both crops and livestock.
23. Moreover, the Ohangwena Region's schools, hospitals, and other institutions will see improved local food security and economic stability.

This will enhance community health and education, providing long-term benefits to the entire region.

24. Having said that **Honorable Speaker**, I would like to submit the following recommendations for the House or Committee's consideration, that we need to:

a) promote and support sustainable agricultural practices that optimize water use efficiency, including drip irrigation, crop rotation, and soil moisture conservation techniques;

b) invest in modern irrigation infrastructure and water distribution systems to minimize water loss and ensure that extracted water is used efficiently;

c) engage local communities in the planning and management of the aquifer's resources through education programs and participation in decision-making processes; and

d) encourage the development of agro-processing industries in the region to add value to agricultural produce, create jobs, and reduce reliance on water-intensive raw agriculture.

Honorable Speaker, Honorable Members,

25. We cannot continue to sit here contemplating how to secure votes from the Ohangwena Region while its people are dying of thirst, and hunger (I am sure you have all seen that footage of people from Ondobe Constituency fighting and scrambling for drought relief food a couple of weeks ago) and being forced to leave their homes to find water elsewhere.

26. Today, we build on what has gone before—and for those who will come after—not by making promises, but by making good on promises. By delivering on commitments. And by having a sense of the future, of where we want to go and the communities we want to build. An inclusive and caring society in which fairness and equality of opportunity are the measures of our progress. Our people deserve it!

27. Therefore, I ask that this motion be adopted and referred to the relevant Parliamentary Standing Committee for investigation. We need a comprehensive report to ensure that the people we profess to care about during election campaigns have access to water and see a significant improvement in their lives, because constantly worrying about lack of water has a detrimental impact on mental and physical health, as well as overall quality of life.

Thank you.